Audio steganography: ultrasonic AM detection, key-based LSB embedding, and a diffusion-based approach

(words: 695)

Link: https://hub.labs.coursera.org/connect/sharedfrwficmn

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Overview

Tasks 3.1 and 3.2 are implemented as Python notebooks: one detects and decodes a code hidden in an ultrasonic band, the other embeds and recovers a text message with a key-based least-significant-bit (LSB) scheme. Task 3.3 reviews a recent diffusion-based method and compares it with LSB.

Task 3.1: Analysis of the suspicious audio

The problem. Four WAV files may carry a four-number code that has been amplitude-modulated (AM) onto an *ultrasonic* carrier and mixed into an ordinary recording, so nothing sounds wrong on normal playback.

Detection. The container headers already narrow the field: the three 48 kHz files have Nyquist headroom (24 kHz) for ultrasound, whereas the 44.1 kHz file barely does. For each file, the detector measures the fraction of spectral energy at or above 18 kHz, a region where natural recordings hold almost nothing. `Ex3_sound4.wav` keeps **10.86 %** of its energy there against 0.006–4.25 % for the others, peaking at **19,001 Hz** (Figure 1). That is the carrier.

```
In [5]: ULTRA = 18000.0
        rows = []
        for name, (sr, x) in signals.items():
            mag = np.abs(np.fft.rfft(x * np.hanning(len(x))))
            freq = np.fft.rfftfreq(len(x), 1/sr)
            m = (freq >= ULTRA) & (freq < sr/2 - 1.0)
            frac = mag[m].sum() / (mag.sum() + 1e-12)
            carrier = freq[m][np.argmax(mag[m])]
            rows.append((name, frac*100, carrier))

        print(f"{"file":<18}{"ultrasonic energy":>20}{"peak freq":>12}")
        print("-" * 50)
        for name, pct, cf in rows:
            flag = "  <== SUSPICIOUS" if pct > 8 else ""
            print(f"{name:<18}{pct:>18.3f}%{cf:>10.0f}Hz{flag}")
```

```
file                ultrasonic energy   peak freq
--------------------------------------------------
Ex3_sound1.wav                 4.246%     18523Hz
Ex3_sound2.wav                 0.014%     18638Hz
Ex3_sound3.wav                 0.006%     21074Hz
Ex3_sound4.wav                10.863%     19001Hz  <== SUSPICIOUS
```

Figure 1: Detection evidence: ultrasonic energy and peak frequency per file; `Ex3_sound4.wav` is flagged automatically.

Diagnosis. Zooming into that band shows a central carrier line flanked by *symmetric sidebands* (Figure 2), the textbook fingerprint of amplitude modulation: AM shifts the message spectrum up around the

carrier and mirrors it on both sides.

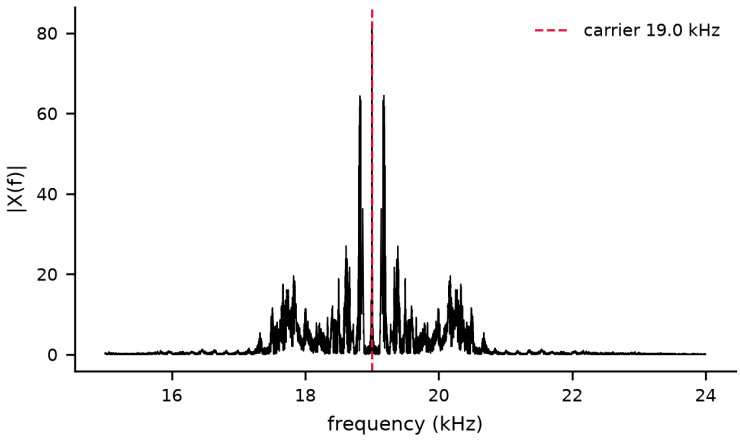


Figure 2: The ultrasonic band of `Ex3_sound4.wav`: a carrier at 19 kHz with symmetric sidebands, the AM fingerprint.

Decoding. The decoder reverses the modulation in three steps: a band-pass filter isolates the carrier; envelope detection via the analytic (Hilbert) signal strips the carrier oscillation and leaves the message; a low-pass filter returns it to baseband. The recovered signal shows voiced-speech harmonics (Figure 3, right) and, played aloud, speaks the code **1891**.

Task 3.2: Embedding a hidden message

Task 3.2 embeds *"It always seems impossible until it's done"* into `Ex3_sound5.wav` and recovers it, improving on plain LSB in three ways. A single integer **key** seeds a pseudo-random permutation of the sample indices, so the message bits are scattered across *non-consecutive* samples, and only the key has to be shared, not the list of positions. Each chosen sample carries **two** least-significant bits, doubling capacity. A 32-bit length **header** is embedded first, so extraction is self-contained: the receiver reads the header, learns the message length, and stops on its own.

Results. The message occupies **184 of 407,280 samples (0.045 %** of capacity); only **132** samples change, each by at most **±3** out of 65,536 (Figure 4), far below the threshold of hearing. The altered samples are sparse and scattered, and the cover and stego spectra coincide, leaving no visible trace (Figure 5). Extraction with the correct key reproduces the message *exactly*; a wrong key selects the wrong samples and decoding fails on invalid UTF-8 (Figure 6), confirming that the key genuinely protects the payload.

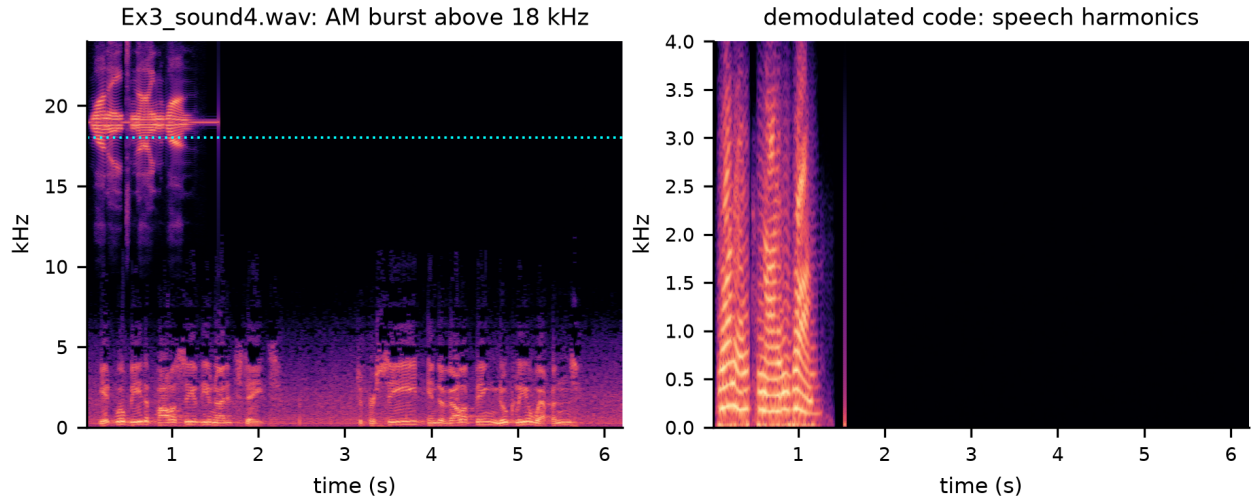


Figure 3. Left: the stego spectrogram; the AM burst sits above the 18 kHz line (cyan) and lasts only the first ≈1.6 s. Right: after band-pass, Hilbert-envelope and low-pass demodulation, the code returns to the audible band as clear voiced-speech harmonics.

```
In [5]: stats = embed_message(INPUT_WAV, OUTPUT_WAV, MESSAGE, KEY, N_LSB)

        print(f'Secret message : {MESSAGE!r}')
        print(f'Stego key      : {KEY}')
        print(f'Bits per sample: {N_LSB}')
        print(f'Samples used   : {stats["slots"]} of {stats["capacity"]} '
              f'({100 * stats["slots"] / stats["capacity"]:.3f}% of capacity)')
        print(f'Samples changed: {stats["changed"]} (max amplitude change +/-{stats["max_delta"]})')
        print(f'Written to     : {OUTPUT_WAV}')

Secret message : "It always seems impossible until it's done"
Stego key      : 20240703
Bits per sample: 2
Samples used   : 184 of 407280 (0.045% of capacity)
Samples changed: 132 (max amplitude change +/-3)
Written to     : out/Ex3_sound5_embedded.wav
```

Figure 4: Embedding evidence: 184 of 407,280 samples used, 132 changed, each by at most ±3.

Task 3.3: A state-of-the-art approach, diffusion-based steganography

Xi et al. (2025) propose a **diffusion-based** audio steganography model.[1]

Characteristics and implementation. Two coupled modules share one denoising-diffusion backbone: a U-Net trained to predict, and therefore remove, the noise added to audio at each diffusion step. The *embedding* module folds the secret bits into the model's starting noise (its latent) and then denoises that latent into natural-sounding stego audio. A psychoacoustic attention map, computed from an STFT, steers the noise away from the low frequencies the ear is most sensitive to. Because the sampling schedule is deterministic (DDIM), the chain is invertible: the *extraction* module simply runs it backwards, from stego audio to latent, and reads the bits out of the latent's DCT coefficient signs, exactly on a clean channel. The framework can even *generate* the cover audio outright, needing no natural carrier. The appendix walks through this pipeline in plain terms.

[1] J. Xi, Z. Xia, W. Zhang, Y. Xie and L. Zhao, "Diffusion-Based Model for Audio Steganography," *Electronics* **14**(20):4019, 2025. https://doi.org/10.3390/electronics14204019.

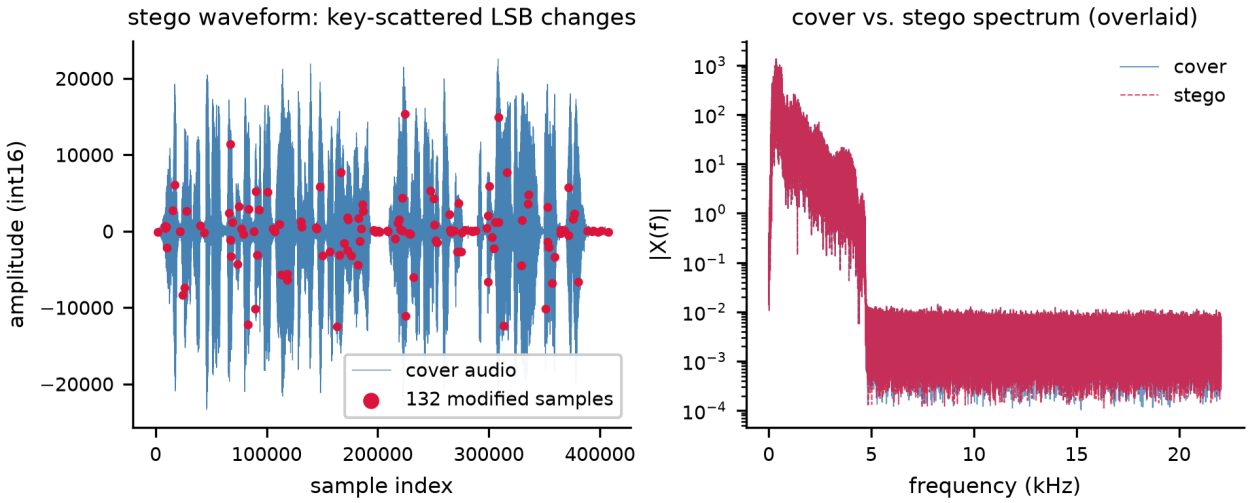


Figure 5. Left: the cover waveform with the 132 key-selected message samples marked in red, sparse and scattered. Right: cover and stego magnitude spectra overlaid; the curves coincide, so the embedding leaves no visible spectral trace.

```
In [6]: recovered = extract_message(OUTPUT_WAV, KEY, N_LSB)
        print(f'Extracted message: {recovered!r}')
        print(f'Matches original : {recovered == MESSAGE}')

        # A wrong key selects the wrong samples: the recovered bytes are noise and
        # usually aren't even valid UTF-8, so decoding fails outright.
        try:
            wrong = extract_message(OUTPUT_WAV, KEY + 1, N_LSB)
            print(f'\nWith wrong key   : {wrong[:30]!r} ...  (matches: {wrong == MESSAGE})')
        except UnicodeDecodeError:
            print('\nWith wrong key   : decoding failed (invalid UTF-8) — message not recoverable')

Extracted message: "It always seems impossible until it's done"
Matches original : True

With wrong key   : decoding failed (invalid UTF-8) — message not recoverable
```

Figure 6: Extraction evidence: the correct key recovers the message exactly; a wrong key fails to decode.

Benefits. The authors report near-transparent quality (PESQ 4.42, SNR 83 dB) and, critically, deep-learning steganalyzers detect the stego audio at only **about 47–62 %**, close to the 50 % chance line, versus **about 76 %** for LSB matching. The method also survives MP3 compression, added noise and resampling.

Comparison with LSB. Table 1 summarises the trade-offs.

Capacity favours LSB, which can claim every cover sample; detectability favours diffusion, and the Task 3.2 key cannot close that gap. Scattering hides *where* the bits sit, but the statistical trace of bit replacement survives, and a steganalyzer needs only the trace, never the key: the key protects confidentiality, not covertness. Diffusion never leaves the trace, because its stego audio is generated from a learned model of natural audio, not edited after the fact. LSB therefore suits benign channels that need simplicity and bit-exact recovery; against steganalysis or lossy transmission, diffusion is the stronger design.

	Key-based LSB (Task 3.2)	**Diffusion (Xi et al.)**
Embedding domain	time (raw sample bits)	learned deep features
Capacity	2 bits per selected sample	0.1–0.5 bits per sample tested
Detectability	high (LSB ≈76%)	very low (≈47–62%)
Robustness	fragile to resampling	survives noise / MP3
Shared secret	one integer key	a trained network
Cost	negligible, CPU	GPU training + inference
Clean recovery	bit-exact, free	exact but costly

Table 1. The key-based LSB scheme of Task 3.2 and the diffusion model of Xi et al., compared.

Appendix: the diffusion pipeline in plain terms

A diffusion model learns to turn noise into realistic data. During training, clean audio is corrupted step by step with small amounts of Gaussian noise, and a neural network (a U-Net) learns to undo one step of that corruption: given a noisy clip and the step number, it predicts the noise that was added. Once trained, the network can start from pure noise and denoise its way, step by step, to audio that sounds natural. Xi et al. build their steganography on three consequences of this design.

Hiding. The secret bits are not written into an existing file sample by sample. Instead they are folded into the starting noise, called the latent: each bit sets the sign of one DCT coefficient of that latent (positive for a one, negative for a zero). Running the denoising process on this shaped latent produces the stego audio.

Recovery. The generator uses the deterministic DDIM variant: the random term in each denoising step is set to zero, which turns the sampling chain into an ordinary differential equation solved with small Euler steps. The same latent therefore always produces the same audio, and the chain can be run in reverse: the receiver, holding the same trained network, walks the stego audio back to its latent, takes the DCT, and reads the signs. On a clean channel, this recovery is exact.

Imperceptibility. While noise is being injected, an attention weight decides where it may go. The audio is mapped to a time-frequency grid with a short-time Fourier transform, a psychoacoustic model scores each bin by how sensitive the ear is to it, and the weights make sure the perceptually critical low frequencies are disturbed least.

The security argument follows from the construction: the stego audio is not a modified natural recording but a sample drawn from the model's learned distribution of natural audio, so a steganalyzer finds no processing artefacts to latch onto. The price is practical: sender and receiver must share the trained network itself rather than a small key, embedding and extraction each cost many network evaluations, and noisy channels raise the bit error rate to roughly 5–6 %.